

1, The History of Islam Is Crucial, Yet Exceedingly Difficult to Study Within China

Among all the chapters I have penned, compared to those where definitive conclusions can be drawn, this is one where I fervently hope to receive professional supplementation. This is certainly not because I am unwilling to conduct rigorous research in this area, but because the objective adversities are simply overwhelming.

As China is one of the extremely few countries worldwide possessing a Great Firewall, domestic sociological research—particularly historiography—has long lingered in a state where black and white are utterly inverted. (*This is because even our government dares not publicly repudiate the fundamental values universally acknowledged by humanity, and thus can only resort to distorting historical narratives to disparage them*). Consequently, it is exceedingly difficult for residents living in China to objectively understand the historical progression of other regions.

Simultaneously, from my personal observation, the magnitude of this difficulty is clearly not uniform when examining different regions.

Excluding nations and regions currently outside China's borders that were historically controlled by China, shared the same cultural sphere, or belonged to "Historical China" (*as defined by Tan Qixiang's Historical Atlas*)—such as Mongolia, Korea, and Vietnam—Japan is indisputably China's most paramount neighbor. Furthermore, the closer we move toward modern historical periods, the greater its significance becomes.

Since its state-formation stage, Japan has long been influenced by China across various domains. Following China's Reform and Opening Up, Japan poured massive investments into China, exerting an enormous cultural impact across two or three generations. Today, Japan is also one of the countries hosting the largest overseas Chinese diaspora, as well as the most favored destination for Chinese outbound tourism and consumption. Even though the social formations of the two nations are now worlds apart, their mutual interactions will inevitably be maintained at a substantial level. Therefore, among all regions outside of China, Japanese history is arguably the easiest for the Chinese people to access and comprehend.

Although Western countries—such as those in Europe, along with the US, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand—are geographically distant from our country, the developed nations of Europe have served as the absolute pillars of human civilization since the Age of Discovery. To this day, the term "Western countries" remains synonymous with economic prosperity, social advancement, and military supremacy.

China has been swept into the Western-dominated world order for nearly two centuries since the modern era. Following the Reform and Opening Up, the sheer advancement of Western nations left an indelible impression on the Chinese populace of that era. Regardless of whether catching up is actually feasible, a vast number of Chinese intellectuals have indeed set surpassing the West as their ultimate goal, and throngs of students travel to these countries for study.

Therefore, even though current official propaganda deliberately fabricates, distorts, and cherry-picks facts to denigrate Western countries and incite public hostility toward them, there is no shortage of people in our country who harbor an affinity for these nations, and their voices can always be heard. Coupled with the colossal volume of economic and human exchanges, there are ultimately still avenues available domestically to learn about Western history. While it is hard to

claim this understanding is exceptionally granular, it is fundamentally sufficient to grasp the overarching picture as a comparative supplement to research on China.

As for the Third World nations of Asia, Africa, and Latin America, although they are framed as our country's "friends and partners" within the official discourse, state-level research on these nations is pitifully scarce. As for the grassroots commoners, they are left entirely in the dark (两眼一抹黑) regarding these regions. From the standpoint of realist diplomacy and economic interests, such an outcome undoubtedly possesses a certain inevitability, but it is exceptionally unforgiving to anyone who actually wishes to comprehend them.

Among these Third World nations and regions, the Islamic states are exceptionally unique. This is because, whether measured by the number of adherents, geographical distribution, or sheer influence, Islam is the *only* global religion truly capable of rivaling Christianity.

Furthermore, during the **Middle Ages** (*referring here to the specific timeframe designated by Europeans as the Middle Ages*), Islam and the Islamic states were unequivocally among the premier protagonists on the world stage. Therefore, if I aim to extrapolate the conclusions I derived from studying Chinese history into universal laws of human society (*if such laws even exist*), a more profound investigation into the history of Islamic civilization is an absolute necessity.

In China, both the official establishment and the grassroots populace hold deeply contradictory attitudes toward Islam.

From the official perspective, among all religions, Islam is the sole religion that has posed an active, preexisting security threat to the Chinese regime. This fact clearly breeds a psychological vigilance against Islam within the government. Yet conversely, they pin high hopes on many Islamic nations to confront the West, thereby benefiting China.

For the grassroots populace, on the one hand, they harbor historical memories of the massive devastation wrought by Islam in the western regions of China throughout history. Consequently, they hold a deep-seated fear and hostility toward it, operating under the ancient maxim: "*If they are not of our kin, their hearts must be alien*" (非我族类, 其心必异).

However, because **social being determines social consciousness** (社会存在决定社会意识), as I stated previously, China is a civilization that utterly failed to complete its **feudalization** (封建化). Therefore, although our country has superficially absorbed many modern elements, the actual cognition of the society remains pathologically conservative. **What Europeans today designate as the "far-right" would be considered pure "leftists" here!** Consequently, rather than finding many of Islam's ultra-conservative values repulsive, the ordinary Chinese commoners actually endorse and resonate with them.

Regardless, for the vast majority of China's non-Muslim population, our knowledge of Islam and the Islamic world is infinitesimally small.

It was not until a few years ago, when the government began championing the "Belt and Road Initiative," that domestic Islamic studies finally caught a political tailwind, translating and publishing works by local Arab scholars regarding Islam and regional history.

However, this is still woefully insufficient to alter the domestic landscape of ignorance regarding Islam—the world's second-largest religion (*and, judging by demographic trends, highly likely to become the religion with the most adherents in the future*).

Setting aside the quantity and quality of these translations, many Middle Eastern countries currently remain in a state of mutual political hostility or mistrust, or suffer from severe domestic political crises. The state of freedom of speech and academic freedom in these countries is deeply concerning. Can we truly trust the academic standards and research outputs of these local scholars implicitly?

I must emphasize what has already transpired in China: When I, as a Chinese citizen, began reflecting on the history of my own country, I discovered that our scholars—especially the architects of the official doctrines—had fabricated countless colossal lies! They had fundamentally distorted China's blatantly obvious historical progression, all to endorse the legitimacy of the current political regime.

This experience forces me to ponder: *Could the exact same thing be happening in other countries?* For a foreigner, being deceived by the lies of scholars from another country is a perfectly normal occurrence. If we observe the current state of "China Studies" in the West, we would harbor absolutely no doubts about this.

As for myself, although I do not identify with Islam, I am not particularly averse to it either. This is not because halal food holds a significant status in the city of Xi'an. Rather, it is because I believe that while Islam might appear conservative and backward to Westerners, **relative to China, it is actually far more advanced!**

Because Islam is, at the very least, a religion that stagnated during the *feudal period* (封建时期); whereas China simply regressed entirely from a feudal class society back into a **restoration-bureaucratic society** (复辟官僚社会)!

For Chinese people like me who grew up in the 2000s, our perception of Islam primarily stemmed from widely popular story collections of the Islamic world, the most representative being *One Thousand and One Nights* (《天方夜谭》) and the *Nasreddin* (阿凡提) tales.

In fact, even from these distant folktales and rumors, I had already discovered that **the Islamic society of the Middle Ages was vastly more open than the Chinese Empire of the Tang and Song dynasties—most notably, it was not nearly as autocratic!**

When the Caliph ordered the demolition of the Lighthouse of Alexandria, the local populace actually spontaneously protested the order and protected the lighthouse, forcing the Caliph to abandon the idea. This incident alone shocked me to my core! Such an occurrence would have been absolutely, fundamentally impossible in the Chinese Empire during the Tang or Song periods.

Nasreddin (阿凡提) is an even more typical example. The fact that a religious cleric could receive such immense respect and courtesy within a Sultan's court, and genuinely intervene to halt the potential evil deeds of the ruling class, is astounding. In China, the only figure bearing any slight resemblance is *Ji Gong* (济公 / the Mad Monk). Yet Ji Gong did not function as a social paradigm in the way Nasreddin did—as a religious figure operating relatively independently of secular power. Ji Gong was more of a pure, fantastical vigilante from a wish-fulfillment novel (爽文游侠).

Later, while watching documentaries introducing the Red Fort built by the Mughal Empire in Delhi, India, I learned that the Muslim Mongol Emperor of India actually constructed a small public audience hall—the *Diwan-i-Am* (覲见厅)—right next to the imperial palace. Its purpose was to allow commoners to directly express their grievances and demands to the emperor.

Although everyone knows such a mechanism could not truly be institutionalized, it nevertheless stood as a symbol and a political gesture.

What I find unforgettable is this: during that very same global eve of the modern era, **what appeared next to the imperial palace in China's Forbidden City was the Grand Council (军机处)**—an institution whose sole purpose was to consolidate the monarch's absolute power and maximize bureaucratic ruling efficiency!

Zakat (天课 / Islamic almsgiving) was another concept that astonished my younger self. To think there is actually a religious doctrine mandating the wealthy to donate a portion of their wealth to relieve the poor! For a region like China, where religious organizations had been practically obliterated during the process of **bureaucratic restoration** (官僚国家), this concept was exceedingly difficult to comprehend.

Therefore, I feel that although Islam is universally demonized, standing in the shoes of a Chinese person who has endured "**Sinicized rule**" (中国化统治), Islam could fundamentally never be *that* terrible. **I harbor a considerable degree of confidence in just how horrifying the land I live on truly is!**

Considering the critical role Islam played in the history of human civilization and its uniqueness in historiographical research, I have set aside my own inadequacy and recorded the questions and perspectives that arose while reading Islamic history. Readers are entirely welcome to question and critique them using scientific methods; it would be even better if knowledgeable individuals could supplement this with crucial primary sources.

As for briefly mentioning Byzantium, it is because I seemingly promised in my earlier writings to supplement it later. Thus, I will briefly narrate the revelations Byzantine history has brought me, illustrating that its historical progression absolutely did not exceed the boundaries of my theoretical framework.

1, 伊斯兰教的历史很重要，但是在国内难以了解

在我写下的所有章节中，这一章比起大多数可以确定结论的章节，它属于非常希望得到专业补充的。这当然不是我不想去认真考虑这一部分的研究，而是客观上的不利因素实在太多。中国作为全世界极少数有互联网墙的国家，国内的社会学（特别是历史学，因为即使我国政府也不敢公开否定人类共同承认的基本价值观，只能通过历史叙述进行贬抑）研究长期处于一种颠倒黑白的状态，在中国生活的居民想要客观了解其他地区的历史进程是有困难的。同时从我的亲身观察来看，这种困难在观察不同地区的时候显然并非等大。除掉蒙古，朝鲜，越南这样在历史时期的本来就被中国控制或与中国在同一文化圈内或属于“历史上的中国”（谭其骧版历史地图集所定义的）在现今中国境外的国家和地区，日本是中国当之无愧的最重要的邻国，而且是越近的历史时期其重要性就越大。日本在国家形成阶段以来长期受到中国各方面的影响，在改革开放之后日本对中国进行了大量的投资，对两三代人产生了巨大的文化影响。现在日本也是海外华人最多的国家之一及中国人最喜爱的海外旅游和消费的目的地，即使社会形态差异已经有天壤之别，两国的往来是怎么都必然维持相当水平，因此日本历史恐怕是所有中国以外的地区里中国人最好了解的。

欧洲和美、加、澳、新这样的西方国家虽然在地理上与我国相隔遥远，但是欧洲发达国家自地理大发现以来就是人类文明的中流砥柱，迄今为止西方国家仍然意味着经济发达，社会先进，军事强大。自近代以来中国被卷入西方主导的世界秩序已经近 200 年，改革开放之后西方国家的先进给当时的中国人留下

了极为深刻的印象，无论能不能赶上，的确有很多中国知识分子以赶上西方国家为目标，很多留学生前往这些国家学习。因此哪怕现在的官方宣传有意捏造歪曲截取事实对西方国家进行贬低并且煽动民众敌视它们，在我国亲近这些国家的人并不少，声音也总能听到。再加上经济和人员往来的总量巨大，在国内要了解西方历史总归是能有些门路的，虽然很难说多么具体细致，不过作为对中国研究的补充进行整体把握也基本足够。

至于亚非拉的第三世界国家虽然在官方语境中是我国的朋友伙伴，但是官方层面对这些国家的研究实在少到可怜，至于民间百姓对于亚非拉地区就更是两眼一抹黑了。从现实主义的外交关系和经济利益来说，这样的结果显然存在必然性，但是对于想要了解的人就太不友好了。在这些第三世界国家和地区中伊斯兰国家尤为特殊，这是因为伊斯兰教无论是从教徒人数，分布范围还是影响力上都是唯一可以与基督教一比的世界性宗教。而在中世纪社会（这里指的就是欧洲人所认为的中世纪的那个时间段）伊斯兰教和伊斯兰国家都是世界舞台上当之无愧的主角之一，因此如果想要把我已经通过对中国历史的研究得到的结论扩大到人类社会的普遍规律（如果可能存在的话），就不可能不需要有关伊斯兰文明的历史进行更为深入的研究。在中国无论官方和民间对于伊斯兰都持有极为矛盾的态度，对官方来说所有宗教中只有伊斯兰教对于中国政权造成了已经存在的安全威胁，这一事实显然使得官方对于伊斯兰教存在警惕的心理，但是另一方面很多伊斯兰国家又被寄希望于与西方进行对抗从而有利于中国。对于民间来说，民众一方面怀有对于历史上伊斯兰教在中国西部地区造成巨大破坏的历史记忆，对其具有“非我族类，其心必异”的恐惧和敌视。但是因为社会存在决定社会意识，如我之前所说，中国是一个没有完成封建化的文明，因此我国虽然表面上接纳了很多现代因素，但社会的实际认识极为保守，现在欧洲人所谓的极右翼在我们这里都是纯粹的左派，因此伊斯兰教的很多价值观念对于普通百姓而言非但不反感反倒是认可的。

无论如何，对中国绝大多数非穆斯林人口而言，我们对伊斯兰教和伊斯兰世界知之甚少。直到前几年官方开始倡导“一带一路”，国内的伊斯兰研究才赶上了一趟政策的顺风车，反映并出版了一些阿拉伯国家本地学者关于伊斯兰教和当地历史的作品。不过这还是不足以改变国内对于伊斯兰这一世界第二大宗教（从人口变化趋势上看，将来很可能是信众最多的宗教）缺少了解的局面，且不论翻译的数量和质量，现在中东很多国家仍然互相处于政治上的敌对或者不信任状态，或者国内政治危机十分严重，这些国家的言论和学术自由情况也是堪忧的，当地学者的研究水平和成果就十分值得信任吗？我必须强调已经在中国发生的事情：当我作为一个中国公民去思考自己国家的历史时，发现我国的学者特别是官方学说竟然撒下了无数弥天大谎，甚至在根本上扭曲了中国原本显而易见的历史进程以为现在的政治合法性背书。这种经历让我不得不考虑其他国家是否也会发生这样的事情？对于一个外国人而言被他国学者的谎言所欺骗是十分正常之事，如果我们注意到现在西方的中国研究是什么情况就绝不会怀疑这一点。

至于从我本人来说，我本人虽不认同伊斯兰却也并不十分反感，这不是因为清真食品在西安这座城市具有什么地位，而是我本人认为伊斯兰教虽然可能在西方人看来是保守的落后的，但是相对于中国来说，甚至要更先进一些，因为伊斯兰教至少是一个停滞在封建时期的宗教，而中国干脆从封建阶级社会退回到官僚社会中了。对于我这样的在零零年代成长的中国人来说，我们对伊斯兰教的认识主要就来源于一些广为流行的伊斯兰世界的故事集，最有代表性的就是《天方夜谭》还有阿凡提的系列故事。事实上，即使是从这些遥远的民间故事和传闻中我就已经发现中世纪的伊斯兰社会远远比唐宋的中华帝国要更为开放，尤其是没有那么专制。当年哈里发想要拆除亚历山大灯塔的时候，当地民众居然自发地反对这一命令并且保护灯塔，哈里发因此也就放弃了这个想法。但这件事情都已经让我足够震惊了，这对于唐宋时期的中华帝国是完全不可能发生的。阿凡提是个更典型的例子，一个宗教神职人员居然能够在苏丹的宫廷中受到如此高的尊重和礼遇，并且真正在制止统治阶级潜在的恶行，这在中国唯一与之有一定相似

的形象就是济公。但济公并没有起到阿凡提那样作为一个相对独立于世俗权力的宗教人员起到社会典范的作用，他更多还是一种纯粹想象的爽文游侠形象。再后来看纪录片的时候看其介绍到印度莫卧儿帝国在德里修的红堡，听说印度的蒙古穆斯林皇帝居然在皇宫旁边修建了一个小小的觐见厅（Diwan-i-Am），其用途在于让百姓直接到这里向皇帝表达诉求。虽然人人都知道这种事情不可能真的制度化，不过也就是一个象征和表态罢了。但是很难让我忘怀的一点是，同样是近代前夜，在中国的紫禁城中皇宫旁出现的是军机处，一个以加强君主权力和统治效率为宗旨的机构。伊斯兰教要求的天课是另一个让少年的我感到惊奇的东西，居然有一种宗教教义，要求富人们捐出自己的一部分钱财去接济穷人，对于中国这种宗教组织已经在官僚复辟过程中被几近摧毁殆尽的地区这是难以理解的。

因此我觉得虽然伊斯兰教被普遍妖魔化，但是站在一个中国人经历了“中国化统治”的立场上，它根本也不可能糟糕的到哪去，我对我生活的土地有多糟糕还是颇具信心的。考虑到伊斯兰教在人类文明史上所扮演的重要角色以及其在历史学研究中的特殊性，我还是不揣浅陋记录下了我在阅读伊斯兰史时遇到的问题以及产生的看法，读到的人只管用科学方法质疑和批判就是，如果有了解的人能够补充一些重要的原始资料就更好了。至于还要提一下拜占庭，是因为我之前在写的时候似乎承诺过日后补充，因此简单叙述一下拜占庭历史给我带来的启示，并说明其历史进程并没有超过我的理论框架。